short-sightedness still has the undesirable consequences that I mentioned. But nowadays, if one were seeking examples of selfish short-sightedness in Britain, one would not look first at the working class. Actually, it is probably best not to burden a scientific work with political asides at all, since it is remarkable how quickly these date. The writings of politically aware scientists of the 1930s—J. B. S. Haldane and Lancelot Hogben, for instance—are today significantly marred by their anachronistic barbs.

***p. 7* … it is possible that the female improves the male's sexual performance by eating his head.**

I first learned this odd fact about male insects during a research lecture by a colleague on caddis flies. He said that he wished he could breed caddises in captivity but, try as he would, he could not persuade them to mate. At this the Professor of Entomology growled from the front row, as if it were the most obvious thing to have overlooked: 'Haven't you tried cutting their heads off?'

***p. 14* … the fundamental unit of selection is not the species, nor the group, nor even, strictly, the individual. It is the gene …**

Since writing my manifesto of genic selection, I have had second thoughts about whether there may not also be a *kind* of higher-level selection occasionally operating during the long haul of evolution. I hasten to add that, when I say 'higher-level', I do not mean anything to do with 'group selection'. I am talking about something much more subtle and much more interesting. My feeling now is that not only are some individual organisms better at surviving than others; whole classes of organisms may be better at *evolving* than others. Of course, the evolving that we are talking about here is still the same old evolution, mediated via selection on genes. Mutations are still favoured because of their impact on the survival and reproductive success of individuals. But a major new mutation in basic embryological plan can also open up new floodgates of radiating evolution for millions of years to come. There can be a kind of higher-level selection for embryologies that lend themselves to evolution: a selection in favour of evolvability. This kind of selection may even be cumulative and therefore progressive, in ways that group selection is not. These ideas are spelt out in my paper 'The Evolution of Evolvability', which was largely inspired by playing with Blind Watchmaker, a computer program simulating aspects of evolution.